

Week 2 Lit Example Reader

MACBETH: SHIFTING WORDS, SHIFTING REASONS

Purpose: This reader gives Macbeth passages for applying Week 2’s logic habit: define your terms, watch for ambiguity, and do not let a word change meaning inside an argument. Read the passages as first-year college students: slowly, precisely, and with special attention to repeated words.

What to watch for: A word can be powerful in poetry and still dangerous in reasoning. Shakespeare often lets a word carry more than one sense at once. Logic does not flatten the poetry; it asks whether an inference depends on one sense of a word quietly becoming another.

Before the Passages: The Week 2 Logic Tool

Whately’s second habit is to keep terms steady. When an argument uses the same word in two senses, the reason may appear stronger than it is. For each passage, ask:

1. **Term:** Which important word or phrase is doing logical work?
2. **First sense:** What does it mean in one place?
3. **Second sense:** Does it mean something different in another place?
4. **Inference check:** Does the argument still work when the two senses are kept separate?

Do not hunt for a fallacy label first. Begin with the words on the page. If the term stays steady, say so. If it shifts, explain exactly how.

Passage 1: Excerpts from Act 1, Scenes 1 and 3 — Fair and Foul

Context: The witches open the play by joining opposites. Later, Macbeth echoes their language before he even hears their prophecy. The repeated language introduces a pattern that continues throughout the play: what appears attractive, favorable, or successful may not be morally good.

Witches. Fair is foul, and foul is fair:

Hover through the fog and filthy air.

Macbeth. So foul and fair a day I have not seen.

Reader Notes

Shakespeare joins outward appearance, favorable circumstances, and moral judgment in the words *fair* and *foul*. Throughout the play, watch whether characters move too quickly from “this appears fair” or “this favors me” to “this is good or right.” Poetry can hold these meanings together; sound reasoning must distinguish them.

Reading task: As you continue through the play, watch for things that appear attractive, favorable, or successful but may be morally corrupt—and for things that appear unpleasant or threatening but may reveal the truth.

Passage 2: Act 1, Scene 7 — What Counts as a Man?

Context: Macbeth has decided not to murder Duncan. Lady Macbeth attacks his resolve by turning the word *man* into a test. Her language matters because she is not merely describing Macbeth; she is pressuring him to accept a definition.

Macbeth. We will proceed no further in this business:

He hath honour'd me of late; and I have bought
Golden opinions from all sorts of people,
Which would be worn now in their newest gloss,
Not cast aside so soon.

Lady Macbeth. Was the hope drunk
Wherein you dress'd yourself? hath it slept since?
And wakes it now, to look so green and pale
At what it did so freely? From this time
Such I account thy love. Art thou afeard
To be the same in thine own act and valour
As thou art in desire? Wouldst thou have that
Which thou esteem'st the ornament of life,
And live a coward in thine own esteem,
Letting "I dare not" wait upon "I would,"
Like the poor cat i' the adage?

Macbeth. Prithee, peace:

I dare do all that may become a man;
Who dares do more is none.

Lady Macbeth. What beast was't, then,
That made you break this enterprise to me?
When you durst do it, then you were a man;
And, to be more than what you were, you would
Be so much more the man.

Reader Notes

Both speakers use the word *man*, but they press it in different directions. Macbeth's sentence sets a limit; Lady Macbeth's reply challenges that limit. From this point on, the reader notes will not supply the two senses for you. Use the passage to decide what each speaker means and whether Lady Macbeth's pressure works logically.

Reading task: Underline Macbeth's sentence about what befits a man. Circle Lady Macbeth's pressure words: *afeard*, *coward*, *dare*, and *man*. Do not write the worksheet answer yet; mark the evidence you will need.

Passage 3: Act 1, Scene 7 — Done Does Not Mean Settled

Context: Macbeth imagines that the murder might be simple if the deed could be finished without consequence. His opening wordplay matters because *done* can mean physically completed, morally settled, or free from future effects.

Macbeth. If it were done when 'tis done, then 'twere well
It were done quickly: if the assassination
Could trammel up the consequence, and catch
With his surcease success; that but this blow
Might be the be-all and the end-all here,
But here, upon this bank and shoal of time,
We'd jump the life to come. But in these cases
We still have judgment here.

Reader Notes

Macbeth repeats *done* because the word is carrying pressure. Do not assume every repetition has the same force. Ask what kind of completion Macbeth is imagining in each phrase, and what kind of completion he cannot actually control. Your worksheet answer should name the senses yourself.

Reading task: Box the repeated word *done*. In the margin, write two possible senses before deciding which ones matter for the worksheet.

How to Use These Passages on the Worksheet

The worksheet will ask you to apply Week 2 logic to Shakespeare's language. Your job is not to summarize Macbeth's ambition or Lady Macbeth's cruelty. Your job is to define the term, keep senses separate, and test whether an inference survives once the word is clarified.

Strong college-level answers should do three things:

- identify the exact word or phrase whose meaning matters;
- state both senses in ordinary language;
- explain how the shift affects the reasoning in the scene.